

Stage 4 — Operational Scaling

Timing: Month 6–9 | Objective: Replace founder-dependent processes with repeatable systems

Primary task

Build the operating system required to handle increasing order volume without a proportional increase in chaos.

Operations

- Create standard operating procedures for vendor onboarding, order exceptions, refunds, disputes, fraud review and support.
- Define service-level targets for customer support and vendor response.
- Track logistics performance by partner, location and order type.
- Create weekly operating reviews covering growth, transactions, support, logistics and cash.

Technology

- Improve observability, alerting, background jobs, webhook reliability and database performance.
- Automate repetitive administrative tasks only after the underlying process is understood.
- Introduce role-based access and audit trails for sensitive administrative actions.
- Establish a disciplined release, rollback and incident-response process.

Team design

- Identify work that should move away from the founder.
- Prioritize operations/customer support and growth responsibilities before adding unnecessary engineering headcount.
- Create clear ownership for product, engineering, operations, growth and finance.

Financial control

- Track GMV, revenue, direct costs, contribution margin, burn, cash balance and runway monthly.
- Separate marketplace money flows from company operating cash.
- Reconcile payment provider settlements, vendor payouts, refunds and escrow balances.

Lean Startup application

- Scale processes that have already demonstrated value instead of scaling unvalidated assumptions.
- Use small controlled changes to avoid losing the ability to identify cause and effect as the organization grows.
- Keep experimentation alive even as operational discipline increases.

Exit criteria

- Core operations can run for a period without constant founder intervention.
- Financial and transaction reconciliation is reliable.
- The technology stack can handle the current volume with acceptable reliability.
- There is a documented operating cadence and ownership structure.

Founder question: Which processes are currently dependent on me personally, and what evidence would justify automating or delegating them?

Framework reference: Eric Ries, *The Lean Startup* (Crown Business, 2011). This roadmap applies Lean Startup concepts such as validated learning, the Build–Measure–Learn loop, minimum viable product (MVP), innovation accounting, and pivot/persevere decisions. It does not reproduce the book's text.